Paul was my boss. He had the authority to confirm the big decision and wanted to make a clean break. As captain, my opinions carried weight. I had a responsibility to communicate the views of other senior players. Like me, they felt it was time to move on without Kevin, so that we could all have breathing room. It was not a final banishment, because in international sport no one can say never, but on a human level I felt a sense of dread. We were dealing with someone with whom I'd shared some magical experiences.

I met Downton and Whitaker in the coffee shop of the Danubius Hotel in St John's Wood, opposite the Nursery End at Lord's. No one was entirely sure how Kevin was going to react when we called him into a first-floor meeting room. I knew what was going to be said. As a player you learn to cope with nerves, but I can't lie. It was a deeply unpleasant experience.

Formalities were icy, as they tend to be in this type of situation in any job. Downton thanked Kevin for his service to English cricket, paid due homage to the magnitude of his career, but ended a brief summary with the words 'we are no longer going to pick you for England'. Kevin was poker-faced, stood up and said, 'OK, thanks,' and walked out of the room.

The meeting had lasted, in my estimation, no more than three minutes. Kevin would later describe me as a 'company man' who looked down at his shoes throughout the process. It's true there were moments when I studied the carpet, because this was not a decision taken lightly, but I made a point of making eye contact. I didn't say a word because there simply wasn't time to do so.

Kevin was a barrier to progress, a source of distraction, and I suspect he knew what was coming. There was a momentary silence when he walked out, a brief calm before the storm. Downton's public suggestion that 'the time is right to rebuild not only the team but also the team ethic' set off a predictable chain of events.

The dignity of Kevin's initial statement, in which he spoke of his pride and honour at playing for England, didn't last. What followed was a classic example of the 'pile on', a social-media phenomenon fuelled by egotism, ignorance, smugness and often superficial anger, which feeds off itself until it assumes a significance out of all proportion to the subject. Just a few people can be very, very noisy.

The campaign against us was well orchestrated and floated on hot air. Its principal cheerleader called me 'a repulsive little weasel', which might have